

CHAPTER TWENTY-SEVEN

Boundaries from Strength

(A Strand Chapter — this one is for you.)

Hi, friend. J.A.R. again.

This is the last strand chapter in this book. I have one more thing I want to tell you, and it is important, and it might seem like the opposite of what I have been telling you for the last twenty-six chapters, but it isn't.

I have been telling you, all book long, to be kind to yourself. To be kind to others. To forgive. To give grace. To extend mercy. To assume the kindest reason. To listen carefully to feelings. To say it straight when you need to.

Now I want to tell you something that goes alongside all of that.

You are allowed to have boundaries.

A boundary is a line. The line says: *this is what I am okay with, and this is what I am not okay with.* The boundary is not mean. The boundary is not selfish. The boundary is information, given to other people, about how you need to be treated.

Some kids are taught — sometimes by their parents, sometimes by their teachers, sometimes just by the way the world works — that having boundaries is rude. That a good kid is one who lets everybody do whatever they want with them. That a kind kid never says no.

This is wrong.

Kindness without boundaries is not kindness. Kindness without boundaries is being a doormat. Doormats are walked on. Doormats wear out fast. Doormats end up tired and resentful and quiet and sad. Doormats are not actually being kind. Doormats are just being afraid to say no.

Real kindness has boundaries. Real kindness comes from a person who has chosen, freely, to give what they are giving — because they wanted to, not because they were too scared to say no.

A boundary is what makes your kindness real.

Here are some boundaries you can have, even as a kid:

1. I do not have to hug people I do not want to hug. Even if they are family. Even if it is Christmas. You can shake their hand. You can wave. You can say hi. You can give them a real warm smile. You do not have to put your body next to a body you do not want your body next to. Your body is yours.

2. I do not have to tell people things I do not want to tell them. Even adults. Even grandparents. Adults who push for personal information you do not want to share are not, in that moment, respecting you. You can say *I would rather not talk about that right now*. You can say *that's private*. You can change the subject. You can be polite about it. But you do not have to share what you do not want to share.

3. I do not have to laugh at jokes that are not funny. Especially if the jokes are mean. Especially if the jokes are about somebody who is not there. Laughing at the joke is, in a small way, joining the joke. You can not laugh. You can say *that's not funny*. You can change the subject. You can walk away.

4. I do not have to be friends with everybody. You can be polite to everybody. You can be kind to everybody. But you do not have to be close to everybody. Friendship is a choice. You

are allowed to choose your friends. You are allowed to decide, for your own reasons, who you spend time with.

5. I do not have to forgive on a schedule. Even if somebody is mad at you for not forgiving them yet. Even if they keep apologizing. You are allowed to take your time. You are allowed to need a while. You are allowed to never forgive — although, as we have learned, that is usually heavier for you than for them.

6. I do not have to share toys, snacks, or favorite things on demand. Even with siblings. Even with friends. Sharing is good. Sharing is something we practice. But being forced to share — every time, of everything, with everybody — is not sharing. That is just losing things. You can share most things. You can have some things that are just yours.

7. I do not have to be in places that feel unsafe. Even if I am told I should be. Even if other kids are there. Even if it would be embarrassing to leave. If a place feels unsafe to your body — you can leave. You can ask a trusted adult to help you leave. You can call your parents.

8. I do not have to say yes to things that drain me. Especially when I am tired. Especially when I have already given a lot. Especially when somebody is asking too much of me. You can say *no*, *thank you*. You can say *not today*. You can say *I need to rest*.

9. I do not have to keep secrets that scare me. This is the most important one on this list, so please listen carefully. If an adult — any adult — tells you to keep a secret from your parents, from your trusted adult, from a teacher, that makes you feel scared or weird in your body — that secret is not safe to keep. You tell. You tell a trusted adult. You tell as soon as you can. Real adults who care about you do not ask you to keep scary secrets. Adults who ask kids to keep scary secrets

are doing something wrong. The telling is not a betrayal. The telling is what good kids do.

10. I am allowed to change my mind. About sharing. About friends. About foods. About hobbies. About what I am willing to do. About what I am willing to put up with. Changing your mind is not failure. Changing your mind is information. You are allowed.

These are your boundaries. They are not the only ones. You can have more. You can write your own. You can talk to a trusted adult about which boundaries are right for you.

The boundaries are a kind of strength, and the strength makes your kindness real.

When you say no to the things that drain you, you have more energy for the things that fill you. When you keep some toys just for yourself, you can share other toys more generously. When you take your time forgiving, your forgiveness, when it comes, is real. When you tell the scary secret, the scary thing has a chance of stopping.

The boundaries do not make you a worse person. The boundaries make you a clearer person. People who love you will respect your boundaries. People who do not respect your boundaries are showing you something important about themselves.

The kids in this book have been learning boundaries all year. They have been doing it in pieces.

Kezia, with the grown-up who is not allowed to come over — that is a boundary.

Maya, with her story — that is a boundary on what the world gets to make her be.

Marcus, with the kid on the bus — that is a boundary on whose words he lets in.

Priya, with her aunt — that is a boundary in formation. She is not all the way there yet. She will be.

Jordan, with the funny — that is a boundary against being only one thing.

Amara, with the letter — that was a boundary against carrying somebody else's job. She handed back the part that was not hers.

Sofia, with her dad — coming up. Boundary in formation.

Theo, with his role as the watcher — he is, in March, learning when watching is not enough, and stepping over the line into action. That is a boundary, too — a boundary against being only one kind of helper.

Darius, with his uncle — coming. He is going to figure something out about how he wants to be around his uncle in the future, and it will not be the same as how his father has been.

All ten of them are building boundaries.

You are building yours, too. You have been building them since you were born. You are going to keep building them for the rest of your life.

The boundaries are not the opposite of kindness. The boundaries are what makes the kindness real.

Carry that.

Okay. End of the last strand chapter. Back to the story.

— J.A.R.